DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Why Were Our Prophets Shepherds?

Derech Hashem 3:5:6-7

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 3, Chapter 5, paragraphs 6-7 (end of paragraph 6 and paragraph 7) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 10 January 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

A continuation

This short recording continues the previous one from the same evening. The group had been discussing how Moshe prepared for prophecy during his long years as a shepherd before the burning bush, and whether he became the great prophet he was all at once.

Who trained Moshe?

The recording picks up with the Rabbi agreeing that it is much harder to be self-trained. A participant asked who trained Moshe in the desert. Perhaps, the Rabbi said, his father-in-law Yitro, with whom he spent those years. A participant raised the Midrash that Yitro was one of Pharaoh's three advisers, with Bilam and Iyov. The Rabbi noted that the different Midrashim do not always fit together: according to one Iyov never existed, and according to another he was one of those advisers.

He also explained Yitro's words to his daughters about the stranger who had helped them: "call him, and let him eat bread". Bread, he said, is a euphemism for marriage: Yitro had seven daughters, and one of them could marry him.

Shepherds and solitude

The more interesting point, the Rabbi said, is that our leaders were shepherds: Moshe, David, and in a sense the Jewish people as a whole. For him this was almost an initiation into contemplation. In nature it is dark and quiet, there is no noise, no materialism, and a person can think.

"I think the reason why we are so detached from spirituality is because we have all the distractions of life." We live in built-up cities with electricity and phones, constant buzzes and news flashes, and no time to meditate. He often wonders where the next generation of thinkers, in Torah and in academia, will come from, when there is so much information and so little time to think.

The Rambam writes that if a person lives in a place where he cannot live a moral life, he should go out to the desert and live there. That, the Rabbi said, is the beauty of a kollel: the space to

immerse oneself in the words of God, though always with balance. Great hakhamim who were deeply involved with people still kept a place in their homes where they could not be disturbed, to study without distraction. A rabbi, he said, needs time to switch off and study without any distractions.

The keys to the whole house

Back to the text, at the top of page 117. Other prophets attained specific details; Moshe was shown all the details of creation and given permission to investigate everything, with keys that were never given to anyone else. That is the meaning of "in all My house he is trusted".

The Rabbi's analogy: if you hire someone to do building work, you give him access to the room he is working on, not to your bedroom. If someone comes to clean the windows, you give him the keys to every room in the mansion. Other prophets received messages about a particular room, a particular topic. Moshe was given a holistic understanding of things.

Paragraph 7: no form at all

The final paragraph is a general statement about all prophets. Whatever a prophet's level, at the same time as he perceives the image given in prophecy, he also understands that God has no form whatsoever. The image is only a means of understanding, created by God to transmit prophecy. A prophet never makes that mistake.

The same was true at Har Sinai, where all Israel reached the level of prophets and "did not see any form". They understood two things together: that God has no form and is free of every imagined image, and that through the prophetic image, as through a mirror, they could understand.

The Rabbi said he had rushed through this and would return to it the following Thursday, together with a practical question: how can ordinary people tell a true prophet from a false one? After that, the series would begin Part 4, the final part of the book.

Summary

- This recording continues the discussion of how Moshe prepared for prophecy.
- The solitude of shepherds made room for contemplation; modern distractions make it hard to think deeply.
- Torah study needs protected, undisturbed time.
- Moshe alone was given the keys to "all My house": a complete understanding rather than single messages.
- Every prophet, and all Israel at Sinai, understood that God has no form; the prophetic image is only a means.

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